Translated from the Greek

From the palace at Alexandria

Greetings, Sofia,

I am Cleopatra, Queen of Egypt, and I write to you from my palace in Alexandria, where the sea breeze smells of salt and the harbor is crowded with ships from many lands. My scribes tell me this letter will travel more than two thousand years to reach you. I have ruled a kingdom since I was about eighteen, yet I have never sent a message so far!

They tell me you love puzzles. Then you would enjoy Alexandria. Our great Library holds scrolls gathered from across the world, and scholars come here to study them. I speak many languages myself, and I am the first ruler of my family to learn the language of the Egyptian people. A queen should understand those she rules, don't you agree?

You also love swimming. Everything in Egypt depends on our river, the Nile. Each year it floods, and when the water sinks back it leaves rich, dark soil where our farmers grow wheat. That wheat makes Egypt wealthy. Even the paper I write on comes from the river: it is papyrus, made from a plant that grows along its banks.

From my window I can see the great Lighthouse, the Pharos, with its fire burning to guide sailors safely into the harbor at night. Sailors from every land speak of it with wonder.

With royal regards,

Cleopatra

P.S. If you could add one scroll to the Library of Alexandria, what would it be about?

REAL HISTORY

The true story behind Cleopatra's letter, for Sofia and a grown-up to read together.

1. Cleopatra VII became queen of Egypt in 51 BC, at about 18. Her family, the Ptolemies, were of Macedonian Greek origin and ruled Egypt for nearly 300 years.
2. Ancient writers say she spoke many languages, and she is reported to be the first ruler of her family to learn the Egyptian language.
3. The Lighthouse of Alexandria (the Pharos) became one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World, and the city's Library was famous for its collection of scrolls.
4. Most of what we know about Cleopatra was written by Greek and Roman writers long after she lived, so historians are careful with some stories.
5. Storytelling: Cleopatra wrote in Greek and never wrote to anyone in the future. This letter imagines what she might say, using true facts.

Write back to Cleopatra!

Write here or on any paper you like. Then ask a grown-up to take a photo of it and upload it in your Letters from History account. Cleopatra's next letter will answer you.